



THE DUDELA CO. PRESENTS

THE DUDELA PREP KIT

Your no-nonsense guide to showing up strong — from week 28 to birth and beyond.

John & Mike

thedudelaco.com

WELCOME TO THE PREP KIT



Meet John and Mike. Real dads. Here to help you in all the ways we wish we had been helped.

Hey. We're genuinely glad you're here.

Not in a cheesy, corporate-guide kind of way. We mean it. Most dads-to-be find themselves somewhere between low-key terrified and completely overwhelmed right around now — and the internet isn't helping. Between the 47-item hospital bag checklists and the unsolicited advice from everyone at work, it's hard to know what actually matters.

That's exactly why we built this.

A quick word about how we're going to talk to you:

Straight. No fluff. No clinical detachment. We're two dads — John and Mike — and we've been in those delivery rooms, had those 2am conversations with our partners, and made a lot of mistakes we can help you skip.

This guide is the thing we wish someone had handed us when we were where you are right now.

Here's the truth about the third trimester: it is a lot. Physically for your partner. Emotionally for both of you. Logistically for your whole life. The stakes feel high because they are high. But here's the other truth — you don't have to be perfect. You have to be present, prepared, and willing to grow.

That's what this kit is for.

What's in This Guide

We've built this around five pillars that represent the full picture of what makes a dad who shows up:

01	Emotional Regulation How to stay calm, process your own feelings, and not become the person your partner has to manage on top of everything else.
02	Financial Stewardship Real numbers, real decisions. Maternity leave, budgets, parental benefits — without the lecture.
03	Active Partnership Showing up during labor, delivery, and the early days at home. Practically. Specifically.
04	Knowledge & Advocacy Understanding what's happening medically so you can be in the room — not just physically but actually present and useful.
05	Family Identity Who are you becoming? Who do you want your kid to know? This one's worth thinking about before the baby arrives.

Each section has a short read, some things to actually do, and a space to think. And at the end of each pillar you'll find our Dudela Recommends section, which is a short list of books and resources we've personally used. No filler. Just the stuff that actually helped.

You've got this. Let's get into it.

— **John & Mike**

P I L L A R 0 1

Emotional Regulation

Staying steady when everything feels like it's moving.

Let's start with the part nobody puts in a baby prep class: you're going through something too.

Your partner is the one growing a human, and that is extraordinary and hard and she absolutely gets the headline. But somewhere in the supporting role, a lot of dads quietly start losing it — anxiety they don't name, stress they don't process, fears they never say out loud. And when that pressure doesn't go anywhere, it comes out sideways. Short fuse. Checked out. The guy who goes quiet when she needs him most.

We don't want that to be you. More importantly — you don't want that to be you.

What emotional regulation actually means

It doesn't mean being a robot. It doesn't mean "man up" or pretend everything's fine. Emotional regulation means knowing what you're feeling, not being ruled by it, and being able to choose how you respond instead of just reacting.

In practical terms: when your partner is scared at 11pm and wants to go to the hospital and you're 90% sure it's nothing — you can hold space for her fear without dismissing it, while also gently grounding the moment. That's regulation. When you're in the room during a scary moment in labor and she looks at you to see if everything's okay — that look is asking you to be regulated.

The three things most dads are actually feeling right now — and aren't saying:

1. Fear — What if something goes wrong? What kind of dad will I actually be?
2. Grief — The life you had is changing. It's okay to feel that even if you're happy.
3. Pressure — Financial, relational, expectation. It stacks up fast.

Naming it helps. A lot.

Research backs this up, but honestly so does common sense. When you can say to yourself "I'm anxious about money right now" instead of just being in a bad mood, you're already in a better position. You're the observer of the feeling, not the prisoner of it.

Try this: at the end of each day this week, write down one word for how you're feeling. That's it. No journaling required. Just one word. It builds the habit of checking in with yourself — which is exactly the habit that makes you steady.

What to do when it gets heavy

You need outlets. Not optional — necessary. Here are the ones that actually work:

- Physical movement. Doesn't have to be a gym. A 20-minute walk counts. Your nervous system needs to discharge.
- Talking to another dad. Not to solve anything. Just to say it out loud to someone who gets it.
- Cutting the doom scroll. Your anxiety doesn't need more material. Social media at 1am is not a coping strategy.
- Saying something to your partner. Not to burden her — to stay connected. "I've been feeling stressed about X" is intimacy. Silence isn't.

Abigail's Corner

Emotional regulation isn't a personality trait — it's a skill. And like any skill, it gets stronger with practice before you need it most.

In my work with kids who have significant emotional and behavioral challenges, the single biggest predictor of how well a child regulates isn't their diagnosis or their history. It's whether the adult in the room is regulated. Kids co-regulate with the adults around them — and so do partners in crisis.

When your partner is scared in the delivery room and looks at you, her nervous system is literally taking cues from yours. Your calm is not passive. It's active support. Start practicing now — not because you're broken, but because this is a learnable thing and the third trimester is the perfect time to build the muscle.

— Abigail Colander, *Special Education & Emotional Regulation Specialist*

Dudela Recommends: Pillar 01 - Emotional Regulation

If you want to go deeper on the emotional side of fatherhood, start here.

"The Intentional Father" by Jon Tyson. This one is about not letting moments slip by unnoticed. It's written from a faith perspective but the core idea applies to every dad: the moments you don't craft on purpose just become noise. Worth your time.

"Storyworthy" by Matthew Dicks. This one surprised us. It's technically about storytelling but what it actually teaches you is how to pay attention to your own life. How to notice what's happening in real time. That skill, noticing, is the foundation of emotional regulation.

Visit thedudelaco.com/kit for more resources we're adding as we find them.

Your Pillar 01 Action Items

- Do the one-word check-in every day for the next week.
- Text one friend — ideally a dad — and be honest about where you're at.
- Identify your one main stress right now. Write it down. Name it.
- Tell your partner something true about how you're feeling. Keep it short. Lead with honesty.



John with Viv, awaiting Lolli and EVJ's arrival.

A note from John

My wife Viv had a high-risk Mo-Di twin pregnancy — that's monochorionic-diamniotic, which means our girls shared a placenta. We were told at 20 weeks that she needed a cerclage. The girls were growth-restricted. We made more trips to the hospital than I can count. Lolli and EVJ were born at 34 weeks, early and small (3lbs!), straight to the NICU for an entire month.

Here's what I remember most: standing in that NICU trying to be calm for Viv while quietly coming apart inside. I held it together in every room that mattered. Then I'd get to the parking garage and just — break for a few minutes. Then go back up.

That wasn't weakness. That was regulation. Feeling it, moving it through, and choosing how to show up. That's the whole thing. You don't have to be fine. You just have to keep going back up.

PILLAR 02

Financial Stewardship

Real money, real plans. No lecture required.

Money stress is one of the top reasons new parents fight. Not because they don't love each other, but because the financial picture changes fast and most couples haven't actually looked at it together.

This section isn't going to tell you to stop buying coffee. It's going to help you look at the actual numbers, make a few key decisions now, and take some specific actions before the baby arrives.

1. What does parental leave actually look like for your household?

Sit down with your partner and map this out together. You need to know:

- How many weeks of paid leave does she have? You? Are either of you planning to use unpaid leave?
- When does her pay stop or change? What's the income gap?
- If you have parental leave available — are you taking it? Even 2 weeks makes a significant difference. Don't leave it on the table.

2. What are your new monthly expenses?

Run this exercise: take your current monthly spending, then add estimates for the following:

Expense	Your estimate
Childcare / daycare	\$____/mo
Diapers & formula	\$____/mo
Health insurance change	\$____/mo
Baby supplies & gear	\$____/mo
Pediatric appointments	\$____/mo
Emergency fund contribution	\$____/mo

3. What's your emergency fund situation?

The general rule is 3–6 months of living expenses in accessible savings. Aim to get to at least one month before baby arrives. Unexpected expenses in the first year are not the exception, they're the rule.

4. Have you set up (or updated) the basics?

- Life insurance — if you don't have it, get a term policy now. It's cheap when you're young and healthy.
- Will and beneficiaries — update them. This is the one everyone avoids and everyone needs.
- Health insurance — check your plan's deductible for delivery. Some families owe thousands on day one.
- Dependent care FSA — if your employer offers it, enroll. Pre-tax dollars for childcare.

Dudela Recommends: Pillar 02 - Financial Stewardship

One book changed how we think about building a family with intention.

"The Family Board Meeting" by Jim Sheils. Short read. Big idea. He makes the case that your family deserves the same intentionality you bring to your work. Treat the people you love like the priority they actually are. Read it before the baby comes.

Visit thedudelaco.com/kit for more.

Your Pillar 02 Action Items

- Map your leave situation this week — both of you, on paper.
- Build the new monthly expense estimate using the table above.
- Check your emergency fund balance today. Write it down.
- Review your life insurance, will, and health insurance deductible before week 36.



Mike & Riley — already teaching her the short game.

A note from Mike

We waited too long to have the money conversation and then had it in week 38 when we were both exhausted and anxious. Don't do that.

Twenty minutes with a spreadsheet in week 30 is worth ten times more than the same conversation after you haven't slept in three days.

PILLAR 03

Active Partnership

Showing up — in the room, at home, and in the small moments.

This is the one that looks the simplest and is actually the most demanding — because it's ongoing. It's not a checklist you complete. It's a posture you hold.

Active partnership means your partner is not managing this alone. It means you're not the assistant — you're the co-pilot. And it starts now, not when the baby comes home.

The Third Trimester: What She Needs from You Right Now

Weeks 28–40 are physically brutal for most women. Sleep is broken, her body feels foreign, anxiety is often at its peak, and the mental load of preparing for this has been building for months. Here's how you show up:

Take things off her plate — proactively, not reactively.

Don't wait to be asked. Most partners in the third trimester are exhausted from the labor of having to manage their partner too. Look around. What needs to happen? Do it.

- Grocery runs. Meal prep. Dishes. Laundry. These are not "helping" — they're your job too.

- Hospital bag. Research it, put it together, check it. Take this off her list entirely.
- Nursery. If it's not done, finish it. If it is done, ask what else needs to be set up.
- Appointments. Offer to come to every OB visit. Ask which ones she really wants you there for.

Learn her love language for this season.

Whatever worked before might be different now. Ask her directly: "What would actually help you most right now?" Then do that thing. Repeat.

Labor and Delivery: Your Role in the Room

A lot of dads go into the delivery room underprepared and end up feeling helpless — or worse, in the way. Here's the truth: you have a real, important job in that room.

Your three jobs during labor:

1. Be her anchor. She's going to look at you during the hard parts. Your face, your voice, your presence — these are regulating inputs for her nervous system. Stay calm. Make eye contact. Say her name. Tell her she's doing it.
2. Be her advocate. Know her birth preferences. If she has a birth plan or strong preferences, you hold that document. You ask the questions. You make sure the team knows what she wants.
3. Be the filter. If nurses or doctors need a response and she's in the middle of a contraction, you can say "give us one minute" and ask the clarifying questions.



All of us together at EVJ & Lolli's FIRST Birthday

A note from Mike — when the plan goes out the window

We had a birth plan. Abigail had thought through every detail — the music, the lighting, how she wanted to move through labor, all of it. Then things shifted fast and the OB called an emergency C-section.

The plan was done. In about 90 seconds we went from one scenario to a completely different one, and Abigail looked at me to see if I was okay. That's the moment I understood what "being the anchor" actually means. It's not about the plan holding. It's about you holding — so she doesn't have to.

Make the plan. Know it cold. And then be ready to let it go and just be there.

Practical things to know before you walk into that room:

- How long early labor typically lasts (long — usually 8–12 hours for first babies). Know the signs.
- The difference between a midwife, OB, and doula — and who's on your team.
- What an epidural involves and roughly when it's typically requested.
- What "pushing" actually looks like and how you can help during it.
- What happens in the first hour after birth — skin to skin, cord clamping, the details.

The First Days at Home



The twins coming home — A crazy difficult first few weeks. Worth every hard moment.

Here's something nobody tells you: the first two weeks are harder than the birth. The birth has an end point. The first two weeks at home feels like it doesn't.

- Protect her sleep. Do the 1am–5am window when you can. She feeds, you handle everything else.
- Manage the visitors. You are the gatekeeper. Nobody gets in without her explicit yes.
- Feed her. Literally. A recovering, nursing mother needs a lot of calories. Put a glass of water in her hand every time she sits down to feed.
- Watch for signs of postpartum depression or anxiety — in her AND in yourself. It's real and it's treatable. Know what to look for.

Abigail's Corner

Postpartum depression and postpartum anxiety are real, common, and treatable — and they don't only happen to moms. Research shows that roughly 1 in 10 new fathers experience postpartum depression, and many more experience anxiety they never name. The signs in dads often look different: irritability, withdrawal, overworking, feeling disconnected from the baby or your partner.

— Abigail Colander, Special Education & Emotional Regulation Specialist

Dudela Recommends: Pillar 03 - Active Partnership

Two resources that actually made a difference in our homes.

"Hunt Gather Parent" by Michaela Doucleff. This one will shift how you think about parenting from the ground up. She embeds with indigenous communities around the world and documents how they raise kids, with way less friction and way more connection than the Western approach most of us default to. Eye opening.

Taking Cara Babies. Not a book, it's a program, and it is the single best resource we've found for sleep. John's twins were sleeping through the night by month two. If you want to actually function as a partner and a dad in those early months, figure out sleep first. Find her at takingcarababies.com.

Visit thedudelaco.com/kit for more.

Your Pillar 03 Action Items

- This week: take three things off her plate without being asked. Don't announce it.
- Ask her directly: "What would help most right now?" Write it down.
- Together: go through the birth plan. Know it cold.
- Pack the hospital bag before week 36.
- Know the number for your OB's after-hours line. Have it in your phone.

PILLAR 04

Knowledge & Advocacy

Understanding enough to be genuinely useful.

You don't need to become a medical professional. You need to know enough to ask good questions, understand the answers, and make informed decisions alongside your partner when it matters.

Third Trimester: What's Actually Happening

What's developing right now:

Weeks 28–32: Brain development is rapid. Fat stores building. Lungs maturing.

Weeks 33–36: Baby is practicing breathing movements. Gaining about half a pound a week.

Weeks 37–40: Considered full term at 39 weeks. Baby is in position (hopefully). Final organ maturation.

Prenatal Appointments: What They're Actually Checking

Third trimester appointments get more frequent — every 2 weeks from week 28, then every week from week 36. They're monitoring:

- Fundal height — measuring growth of the uterus as a proxy for baby's growth.

- Blood pressure — watching for signs of preeclampsia, which can develop late in pregnancy.
- Baby's position — is baby head-down? Breech? This matters for delivery planning.
- Fetal movement — you should both be tracking this. The "kick count" is real. Know the baseline.
- Group B Strep test (GBS) — routine around week 36. Positive result means antibiotics in labor. Not a crisis.

Signs That Need a Call or a Visit

Know these. Don't wait to look them up at 2am.

Call your OB / go to L&D if:

Decreased fetal movement — fewer than 10 movements in 2 hours (after 28 weeks).

Contractions before 37 weeks that are regular and/or intensifying.

Sudden severe headache, vision changes, or swelling in the face/hands — potential preeclampsia.

Heavy bleeding (spotting can be normal; soaking a pad is not).

Signs of water breaking — a gush or continuous slow trickle.

Gut feeling. Seriously. If something feels wrong, call.

Being an Advocate in the Medical System

Hospitals move fast. Medical decisions get made in moments. Your partner may be in too much pain or too medicated to process information clearly. This is where you step in.

A framework that works — BRAIN:

The BRAIN Decision Framework

Use this whenever a medical team proposes something unexpected:

B — Benefits: What are the benefits of this recommendation?

R — Risks: What are the risks?

A — Alternatives: Are there alternatives?

I — Intuition: What does my partner's gut say?

N — Nothing: What happens if we wait or do nothing?

You're not being difficult. You're being responsible. Good medical teams expect informed patients and partners. It's okay to ask for a minute. It's okay to ask a question twice.

A note from John

During Viv's pregnancy, there were moments in the hospital where a doctor would walk in, say something fast, and walk out — and I had no idea what had just happened. I didn't know the terminology. I didn't know what questions to ask. I just nodded. And then I'd go find a corner of the hallway and frantically Google what they'd said.

The BRAIN framework is what I wish I'd had in those hallways. Five letters. It slows the moment down enough to ask one good question. That's all advocacy really is — one good question at the right time.

Your Pillar 04 Action Items

- Learn the kick count protocol. Set a baseline this week.
- Know the BRAIN framework. Put it in your phone if you need to.
- Ask the OB at your next appointment: "What are the signs we should definitely call about?"
- If you haven't taken a childbirth class yet — do it. Any class is better than none.

PILLAR 05

Family Identity

Who are you becoming? Who do you want your kid to know?

This is the one most prep guides skip. Not because it doesn't matter — it matters more than almost anything else — but because it's harder to put on a checklist.

So we're going to ask you some questions. And we want you to actually sit with them.

1. What kind of dad do you want to be?

Not in a generic sense. Specifically. When your kid is 8 and they describe their dad to a friend, what do you want them to say? Write that down. It becomes your compass.

The dads we admire most didn't show up that way by accident. They had an intention. It doesn't have to be complicated — "I want to be the dad who's present and calm" is a powerful and sufficient north star.

2. What did you get from your own dad — and what are you choosing differently?

This isn't about blaming your parents. It's about clarity. The dads who don't look at this tend to repeat what they received on autopilot — good or bad.

Try this reflection:

What's one thing your dad did that you want to replicate?

What's one thing you want to do differently?

What's one thing you never got that you want to make sure your kid gets?

3. What are the values your family is going to live by?

Before the kid is here is the perfect time to talk about this with your partner. You don't need a laminated family manifesto. You need a loose shared sense of what matters.

- What does success look like for a kid in our family?
- What role does faith / spirituality play in how we raise them?
- How do we handle conflict and discipline?
- How much do we prioritize family time vs. individual independence?
- What do we want our home to feel like?

Your Identity as a Couple Is Changing Too

Having a baby doesn't just add someone to your relationship. It reorganizes it. The couple dynamic you've built — the rhythm, the inside jokes, the spontaneous weekends — that version of your relationship is changing.

Have this conversation before baby arrives: "What do we want to protect about us — even after baby comes?" Could be a weekly dinner. Could be the morning coffee ritual. Identify it. Commit to it.

A note from both of us:

The identity shift into fatherhood is one of the most disorienting and profound things that will ever happen to you. It's okay for it to feel big. It's okay to grieve the old life a little while also being grateful for the new one. Both things are true.

The men who navigate this best are the ones who are honest about both.

A note from Mike

Before Riley was born, Abigail and I talked about the kind of home we wanted to build. Not the house — the feeling. We said things like “we want her to feel safe being honest” and “we want to be a family that actually talks.” Simple things. But saying them out loud before she arrived made them feel like commitments instead of nice ideas.

That conversation — twenty minutes on the couch in week 34 — has become the reference point we go back to whenever we’re not sure what to do. Do the questions in this section together. Write something down. It doesn’t have to be perfect. It just has to be said.

Your Pillar 05 Action Items

- Write down your answer to: "When my kid is 8, what do I want them to say about their dad?"
- Do the three-question reflection above. Take 20 minutes. It's worth it.
- Schedule a conversation with your partner about family values before week 36.
- Identify one ritual or connection point you want to protect after baby arrives.

You're More Ready Than You Think



Everyone at different stages of the journey

Nobody walks into parenthood ready. Not in the way you feel ready for a job you've trained for. This is different. You learn it by doing it, by failing at it, by getting up the next day and trying again.

What this guide has given you isn't the complete picture — no guide could. What it's given you is a framework. Five pillars that, if you keep coming back to them, will keep you oriented. Emotionally present. Financially prepared. An active partner. Informed. Clear on who you want to be.

That's the dad you want to be. Not perfect. Not always certain. But showing up.



One last thing from John:

The moment they put my daughters in my arms, I didn't feel some mystical wave of instant perfection. I felt terrified and overwhelmed and I had no idea what I was doing. I also felt more purposeful than I'd ever felt in my life. Those two things coexisted. They still do. That's the job. And it's worth it.

One last thing from Mike:

My daughter Riley is going to know me as her dad for the rest of her life. That's the longest relationship I'll have with another person. I try to make decisions from that perspective. Not from the 2am exhaustion or the bad day at work or the fight we had last week. From the long view. From the person I want her to know I was.



WHAT'S NEXT



John & Mike — The Dudela Podcast studio, Denver CO

Check our Recommendations

thedudelaco.com/kit

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Keep going.

— *John & Mike, Dudela*

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